The Effect of Exercise on Preventing Postpartum Depression

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Background

- Approximately 10-13% of postpartum women experience depression.
- Only 10% of women who have postpartum depression seek treatment.
- It is important to examine interventions that may prevent the onset of postpartum depression.
- Exercise is effective for treating depression among adults but few studies have examined its effect on postpartum depression

Purpose

➢To examine the efficacy of an exercise intervention compared to a wellness/support contact control condition on the efficacy of preventing postpartum depression



Methods

- Participants were recruited during pregnancy or after delivery.
- Participants were randomized to the telephone-based exercise intervention or wellness/support control once healthcare provider consent to exercise was obtained during the postpartum phase.
- The exercise arm received a telephone-based counseling intervention based on Social Cognitive Theory and the Transtheoretical model. The intervention lasted six months and participants were contacted monthly during the first month, bi-monthly during months 2 and 3, and monthly during months 4-6.
- The wellness/support arm received information related to wellness such as stress, sleep, and nutrition. The intervention was delivered on the same schedule as the exercise arm but information regarding exercise was not provided.
- Depression was assessed at six months using the Structured Clinical Interview for DSM Disorders (SCID)

Results

- 92% of the exercise participants and 98% of the control participants were retained at 6 months
- There were differences between the groups on meeting the diagnostic criteria for depression at 6 months (8% in each condition met criteria for depression).
- After controlling for baseline depressive symptoms and condition, participants who exercise exhibited fewer depressive symptoms than participants who did not exercise

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Conclusions

- The rate of depression for both groups was lower than expected for this population of at risk postpartum women.
- Even though exercise does not appear to be superior to a wellness/support intervention for preventing diagnosed postpartum depression, our findings suggest that exercise may play a role in reducing depressive symptoms.
- Additional research is needed to better understand the role of exercise and support on preventing postpartum depression.

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